

IN TEST: 10 PERSONAL FIREWALLS

In the Line of FIRE

Protect your PC from security breaches with a personal firewall. A look at the best of these

MOHAN KRISHNAN

Paranoid or simply stupid? Either way, you are capable of wreaking havoc on your system. A little bit of sanity and patience, on the other hand, can get you a perfect system working to its optimum. The same logic can be applied to personal firewalls. Today, you have a number of options to choose from in this category—some paid, some free. And depending on your outlook and skill, you can configure your firewall such that you are totally cut off from the rest of the world, or the entire world has access to your hard disk contents.

What exactly does a personal firewall do? A firewall, to put it very simply, acts as a filter between you and your network connections (including Internet connectivity). It wards off intrusion attempts, Trojans and other malicious attacks. Personal firewalls are meant for the home user or for the desktop user in a networked corporate environment. They aim to block simple attacks, unlike the enterprise-level firewalls that the corporate world uses at the server or router end. These are more complex and are geared towards keeping the server up all the time and protecting the entire network.

But do you really need a personal firewall? Broadband, increase in security attacks, bugs in everyday software, etc, would seem to suggest so but then again, you might think that behind the

Imaging: Neeta Wadiker